



Accreditation Update

The ACEN 2023 standards and impact of accreditation on the quality of nursing education



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ABSTRACT

Background: After obtaining the Board of Commissioner's approval, the Accreditation Commission for Education in Nursing (ACEN) released the 2023 Standards and Criteria in July 2022. Beginning January 2024, all programs seeking initial or continuing accreditation with the ACEN will be required to use this set of Standards.

Innovation: The 2023 Standards and Criteria were revised to apply to all nursing education program types and the Standards were designed to delineate the measurable quality indicators through explicit Criteria Statements for contemporary nursing education.

Implications: The changes to the ACEN Accreditation Standards are expected to increase clarity of the Standards for nursing education programs. The revised 2023 Standards and Criteria identify and describe the essential elements of a quality nursing education program.

Conclusion: An understanding of the key concepts in the 2023 Standards and Criteria will provide the nurse educator with a foundation for developing and maintaining quality nursing education practices consistent with the ACEN Accreditation Standards.

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Introduction/Benefits of ACEN Accreditation

Accreditation is a peer-reviewed, self-regulatory process whereby educational institutions and/or programs are reviewed according to standards that reflect educational quality. In the United States, accreditation is typically a voluntary process. However, the National Council for State Boards of Nursing (NCSBN) has advocated that all states require accreditation; currently, nearly 30 states require accreditation at some level for pre-licensure nursing education programs. The ACEN is the original and most experienced nursing accrediting agency in the United States and internationally. A primary purpose of the ACEN is to develop and maintain nursing education quality expectations, which are reflected in agreed upon Standards and the Criteria statements that provide measurable elements for the peer review process.

The ACEN is a supportive partner with programs in obtaining and maintaining accreditation to strengthen the quality of all levels of graduate and undergraduate nursing education. A primary benefit of ACEN accreditation is the recognition that the program has been evaluated (and periodically re-evaluated) against standards of nursing educational quality by a qualified, independent group of peers.

Having ACEN accreditation can also assist in student recruitment, as it signals to the community that graduates have completed a high-quality nursing program and should be competent practitioners. Nursing programs also benefit by having an increase in faculty engagement in ongoing systematic self-evaluation and quality improvement.

This article will review the process for the development of the ACEN Standards and how these standards, including recent changes resulting in publication of the *2023 Standards and Criteria*, promote nursing education quality. This article will also describe how the ACEN review process promotes quality nursing education.

Development of the ACEN Standards and Criteria as Quality Nursing Education Indicators

When considering the impact of accreditation on nursing educational quality, it is important to note the process for developing quality standards for nursing education programs. Consistent with the requirements of the United States Department of Education (USDE) and Council for Higher Education Accreditation (CHEA), there is a regular, systematic, comprehensive review of the ACEN accreditation Standards approximately every five years by all stakeholders to ensure that standards demonstrate relevancy and continue to evaluate quality nursing education. The *2023 Standards and Criteria* were

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approved by the Board of Commissioners in 2022. As of January 1, 2024, all ACEN-accredited programs and programs in candidacy must use the *2023 Standards and Criteria*.

The Standards review process begins with identification of stakeholders, including nurse educators, administrators, and students from ACEN-accredited programs, as well as nurse clinicians. In addition, there are members of the public, including those who have no relationship with nursing education or practice. For the *2023 Standards and Criteria*, 117 individuals volunteered to be on the task force to develop the new Standards. Thirty-four individuals were selected to represent each of the stakeholder groups. In addition to those selected for participation, ACEN staff and representatives from the Board of Commissioners were included. The task force worked for a year on the development of the 2023 Standards, which included two public comment periods where more than 5,000 comments were received. Public comments were reviewed by the task force and incorporated into the revisions; the recommendations were then sent to the Board of Commissioners for approval. This robust process helps to ensure that the result is the best possible reflection of Standards for quality nursing education.

Historically, the ACEN has published separate Standards for each program type (e.g., practical, associate, baccalaureate), and there were six Standards. The task force recommendation approved by the Board of Commissioners resulted in one set of five ACEN Standards that apply to all program types. Each Standard represents one element of quality nursing education. Within each Standard, Criteria have been developed that further delineate the measurable quality indicators of the Standard. The ACEN Standards and Criteria (ACEN, 2023d) provide a framework and support for quality nursing education worldwide. Regardless of the nursing program type, where the program is located, whether the institution is public, private, religious, or hospital-based, all nursing programs should be designed and implemented to ensure that these peer-identified elements of educational quality are achieved and maintained.

How the ACEN Standards and Criteria Promote Quality in Nursing Education

Although each Standard is written in broad language, the Criteria for each Standard are the subcomponents that further elucidate how the Standards support quality education. While some of the Criteria are quite explicit and are based on requirements from the USDE's expectations, such as measures of program length, record of student complaints, and Title IV compliance, most of the Criteria were developed by the task force based on their knowledge of best practices in nursing education. The ACEN Directors believe it is important to know how each ACEN Standard sets quality expectations for nursing programs. What follows is a review of a few key changes and important concepts in the *2023 Standards and Criteria* that will have a positive impact on the quality of nursing education.

Standard 1: Administrative Capacity and Resources

Standard 1 sets the benchmarks for how nursing programs can demonstrate the administrative capacity and sufficiency of resources to function effectively. This Standard includes Criteria expectations for having qualified and experienced administrators and support staff as well as the financial and physical resources to provide a quality nursing education. Further, this quality must also extend to each location where the program is offered and whenever distance education (as defined by the ACEN) is used to educate nursing students.

There are a few key changes to highlight in Standard 1. First, although access to graduate-level education has improved significantly, there have been challenges for programs to find qualified individuals to lead nursing programs. Some of these challenges may be

regional, and some may be due to the time and financial commitment for talented individuals to obtain an advanced degree. In response, the ACEN has aligned the educational requirements for nurse administrators with the requirements of the governing organization (e.g., college) and state regulatory agencies (e.g., board of nursing). This change should provide the flexibility needed by some programs to maintain accreditation and to support the development of leadership skills within their faculty. This flexibility in educational requirements for the nurse administrator also prompted another important change in the Standard, which now explicitly states that nurse administrators must develop and maintain expertise in administration and leadership. The expectation is now clear that a nursing program should have a leader who is not only educationally qualified but also develops and maintains the knowledge and skills necessary to effectively lead a quality nursing education program.

Standard 2: Faculty

Standard 2 sets expectations about faculty, including that they be educationally qualified, experienced, and sufficient in number to provide students an effective nursing education. There are also some Criteria in Standard 2 that provide faculty protections, such as having policies and requirements for orientation, mentoring, and evaluation of performance. As mentioned previously with the nurse administrator position, the program is expected to hire faculty who meet the governing organization's educational qualifications for the role as well as any regulatory agency requirements. While this is not a change for the Standard, what is made more explicit in the *2023 Standards and Criteria* are the expectations for part-time faculty. It is essential that all nursing faculty, not just full-time faculty, are educationally and experientially qualified, oriented, and mentored, and have their performance evaluated. Therefore, Standard 2 includes separate Criteria or Sub-criteria for full- and part-time faculty.

Standard 2 also provides guidance expectations for faculty development and expertise. For example, faculty should have experience and/or professional development in the content they teach. Additionally, if using distance education (as defined by the ACEN), then faculty must also have experience or professional development for that delivery method. A change for Standard 2 is related to faculty expertise. Once again, the new Standards have this Criterion separated for full- and part-time. This intentional emphasis on full- and part-time faculty is important to ensure quality teaching by all faculty working with nursing students. What is also new with the expectations for full- and part-time faculty is for programs to describe specific areas of faculty expertise. Although expectations for faculty have always included *evidence-based teaching*, additional and explicit expectations have been added. One new expectation is *standards of clinical practice*, which is important (particularly for full-time faculty who may only be teaching in the classroom setting). Another expectation is related to student *assessment and evaluation* since it was identified by the task force that some programs that have struggled with their curriculum and outcomes have faculty members who may not be developing or maintaining their expertise in assessment and evaluation, which may contribute to a decline in student learning as well as program outcomes. Expectations related to cultural diversity have always been included in the curriculum Standard; however, it became clear that faculty struggled to bring these concepts into the curriculum because they did not always engage in related professional development. By including the principles of diversity, equity, and/or inclusion in the faculty expertise Criterion, programs are directed to ensure faculty receive this support to provide a nursing education environment that meets the needs and supports the learning of all nursing students. Again, these topics are explicit expectations for full- and part-time faculty to bring attention to the

development of *ALL* faculty in key areas that impact the quality of nursing education.

The final change to mention in Standard 2 is related to preceptors. There has always been a Criterion related to the use of preceptors, including their qualifications, orientation, mentoring, and monitoring to ensure quality clinical experiences for students. Additionally, it was always required that programs address preceptor roles and responsibilities. The change in the *2023 Standards and Criteria* is that preceptor responsibilities *may include* input into student evaluation. This change occurred because it was identified that some faculty were relinquishing their student evaluation responsibilities to the preceptor, who was not qualified for that role. The ACEN has always defined faculty as anyone who is teaching and/or evaluating students, and those individuals must meet the qualifications for faculty. In most cases, preceptors are not qualified to be faculty, and nursing faculty are ultimately responsible for all student-related decisions, including evaluation. However, it is appropriate for preceptors to provide feedback to the faculty about student performance. This change is intended to make preceptor roles clear and to ensure the quality and consistency of student evaluation processes.

Standard 3: Students

Standard 3 is about Students, and the Criteria in this Standard promote the accuracy and consistency of program information, such as student policies for admission, progression, and complaints, while ensuring that students are well-informed about the program and any changes that may occur during their program of study. Quality nursing education programs should also have sufficient support services for students, and student educational and financial records must be maintained securely. Standard 3 outlines these student-related quality indicators; while much of the content is the same as it was in the 2017 Standards, the formatting was revised, and Criteria were re-sequenced to enhance the flow. However, one notable difference is related to explicit requirements for student policies. While most institutions and nursing programs have many policies and procedures, the task force identified essential policies that must be developed to be non-discriminatory and implemented as published. Key student policies include admission, progression, graduation, complaints and/or grievances, and technology requirements. This guidance helps ensure that student expectations and requirements are clearly stated. The expectation is that student policies apply to all program options, all locations where the program is offered, and for those engaged in distance education (as defined by the ACEN). This expectation is to ensure the consistency of the nursing education experience for *all* students.

Standard 4: Curriculum

Standard 4 is about curriculum. Quality nursing programs must have curriculum that is current, organized, and designed by faculty to assist student learning as they progress through the program of study, graduate, pass the licensing examination, and become employed as a nurse. Standard 4 includes expectations related to general education and prerequisite coursework, nursing courses, and practice learning experiences in skills, simulation, and/or clinical settings that are appropriate for the level of education offered and meet any credit or clock hour requirements of the governing organization and regulatory agencies. A quality nursing curriculum should include a variety of instructional strategies and learning activities, and the ACEN Standards have included this expectation. Additional clarity about expectations for student evaluation has been added to the 2023 Standards to ensure that there is a variety of formative and summative evaluation methods to ensure appropriate assessment of student learning in all learning environments. The use of formative and

summative evaluation methods is critical as far as ensuring that students receive performance feedback and that they meet program expectations for progression and graduation.

Standard 4 also includes a new Sub-criterion ensuring that the curriculum is implemented as published. One reason for this addition was to ensure that the number of contact hours required for the credit hours awarded were completed in accordance with governing organization and/or program requirements. As noted in Standard 2, faculty are expected to develop and maintain expertise in nursing education, and an essential component of curriculum is the consistent and policy-based application of credit and contact hours for students.

Another key change in Standard 4 is related to the integration of new contemporary concepts within the curriculum. Cultural diversity concepts in nursing curriculum were previously expected, as were evidence-based practice, information literacy, and interprofessional collaboration. However, with the *2023 Standards and Criteria*, the task force felt it was important to ensure faculty included other concepts, such as delegation, professional identity, and scope of practice. Clearly, quality nursing curriculum includes many more concepts; however, the explicit inclusion of these concepts emphasizes the foundational importance of these topics for all nursing students.

The final key change in the Standard is related to skills, simulation, and clinical/practicum experiences. The [ACEN Glossary \(2023a\)](#) is clear that clinical/practicum experiences consist of direct, hands-on care, which is required for all program types and all program options. Historically, some program faculty have believed that clinical/practicum learning experiences were optional. As a practice-based discipline, the ACEN is clear that *ALL* nursing students should engage in clinical/practicum learning experiences. Therefore, the *2023 Standards, the Criteria* were written to ensure that all programs understand the expectation by explicitly separating the skills and simulation Criterion from the clinical/practicum Criterion. In summary, in accordance with best educational practices, all ACEN-accredited programs and program options must include a clinical and/or practicum component as defined by the ACEN.

Standard 5: Outcomes

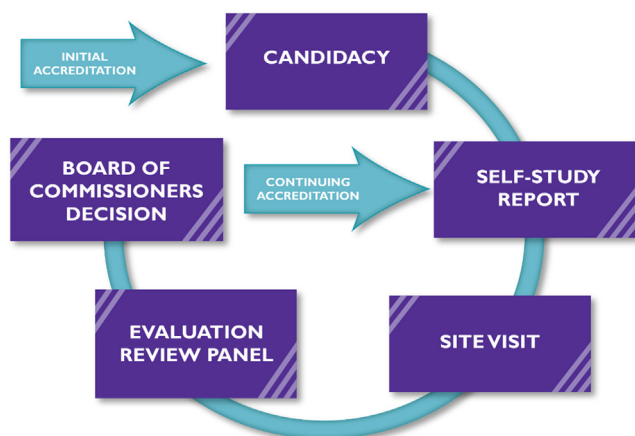
The final Standard is the Outcomes Standard. Standard 5 expects faculty to evaluate the effectiveness of the curriculum by assessing outcomes data, which includes student achievement of the end-of-program student learning outcomes (SLOs), program completion rates, licensure examination pass rates, and job placement rates. Just as the faculty are responsible for the nursing curriculum, they are also responsible for the assessment of the curriculum's effectiveness through program evaluation. For the *2023 Standards and Criteria*, there is emphasis on the faculty's role using a *written plan* for assessment to evaluate program effectiveness.

The Board of Commissioners' decision data, demonstrated in the annual *ACEN Report to Constituents* ([ACEN, 2023c](#)), revealed that this is the Standard most likely to be found in non-compliance or with areas needing development, and these data were used to revise the 2023 Standards. To provide more guidance and clarity in the expectations, the task force included redundancies in each Standard 5 Criterion to assist faculty in using best assessment practices to promote quality improvement. One best practice in assessment is disaggregating data to promote meaningful analysis. For example, programs may have different program options, locations, or student populations. Aggregate data on student learning achievement may hide patterns of performance within identified sub-groups. By disaggregating the data, faculty can identify differences to target interventions and improve outcomes for those students. Faculty are also expected to document their assessment practices, which provides not only evidence for their peers, but a historical record of the faculty's plan and work in the event

of leadership and/or faculty changes as well as during accreditation visits. Lastly, there is an expectation to share the data analysis with communities of interest. This may include employers, graduates, students, and other educational or healthcare agencies. By sharing the analysis of the outcomes assessment data and receiving input from these stakeholders, the faculty may gain additional insights about how to improve the quality of their nursing education program.

ACEN Accreditation Process Promotes Quality in Nursing Education

Next is a brief overview of the accreditation process to show how it promotes educational quality. Each program seeking initial or continuing accreditation with the ACEN must participate in a self-evaluation regarding the program's compliance with the Standards and Criteria. This first step of the accreditation process results in the development of the full Self-Study Report, which includes all five Standards and all Criteria within each Standard. Supporting evidence for the narrative of the report is also necessary and assembled by the faculty. The process of self-evaluation during Candidacy and in preparation for either an initial or a continuing accreditation site visit is a *valuable experience*. This is especially true for programs that are new to accreditation, as it may be the first time there has been a total assessment and reflection on the effectiveness of the program. This process frequently identifies areas where the program faculty must make changes and improvements to be successful in achieving accreditation. These changes help to ensure quality improvements for each program undergoing review.



After the program has submitted its Self-Study Report, the second step of the process involves a team of peer evaluators who review the program's report and the evidence of compliance submitted by the program; the team then prepares for an onsite visit to the program. Onsite, the visiting team writes a site visit report based on their findings during the review of program materials prior to and during the visit. The team makes a recommendation about the accreditation status for the program, which is based on its review of the total program. At the end of the onsite visit, the team provides the preliminary findings to the program. These findings may include suggestions for improvement as well as compliance or non-compliance with the Standards and Criteria. In response to these findings, the faculty can make any necessary quality improvements and provide evidence to support those changes before the third step of the peer review process, the Evaluation Review Panel (ERP). ERP consists of different volunteer peer evaluators. This panel completes its own review of the program materials, site visit team findings and recommendations, as well as the program's response. The ERP reaches a consensus on their

findings to make a recommendation about the program's accreditation status to the ACEN Board of Commissioners (BOC). The BOC review is the final step of the peer review process; the Board consists of nurse educators, clinicians, and public members. The Board reviews the program materials, the Site Visitor's Report and recommendation, the program's response, as well as the ERP findings and recommendations. The Board then makes the accreditation decision, which is shared with the program, and may provide additional guidance for quality improvement. As you can see, ACEN peer review is an intensive process that provides multiple steps to assure program quality is accurately determined and then maintained by programs over time.

The ACEN also reviews the effectiveness of accreditation annually thorough the Annual Report process. Each year, data are collected from each ACEN-accredited program regarding program demographics as well as program outcomes. These data are compiled in an annual *Report to Constituents*, which is available on the ACEN website, and provides faculty with an opportunity to compare their own program with other ACEN-accredited programs. One example of the effectiveness of ACEN accreditation in nursing education identified in the *Report to Constituents* is performance on the NCLEX®. ACEN program graduates represent most newly licensed nurses in the U.S. annually. And, as the report indicates, ACEN-accredited programs consistently outperform the national average for all first-time test-takers on this licensing examination. The *Report to Constituents* informs the public how well programs are doing with the quality Standards through the reporting of accreditation decisions made by the BOC. As noted above, changes to the Outcomes Standard were implemented to address these accreditation decision trends. Additionally, significant findings or patterns in these data help the ACEN Directors with developing educational materials to support program faculty with their work and promote the ACEN mission of improving the quality of nursing education.

ACEN Resources

An important part of the ACEN mission is to be a supportive partner in promoting quality nursing education. To that end, the ACEN provides numerous accreditation resources on its website, including the Standards and Criteria, the ACEN Glossary, all educational events, such as Self-Study Forums and conferences, and a list of all the ACEN staff, current Board members, and volunteer peer evaluators. The ACEN Glossary is online and provides definitions for frequently used terms in the ACEN Standards and Criteria and other accreditation documents. The ACEN Accreditation Manual, which includes general information, policies, and an international supplement, is also accessed on the website. Finally, faculty can sign up online to receive news alerts and the *Bridges* newsletter. A recent *Bridges* edition included an article about the ACEN's position on the use of high stakes standardized testing, which is not a best practice in education. The ACEN Directors are sharing this article to promote the appropriate use of standardized testing products and high stakes testing in all its forms (ACEN, 2023b).

Another unique and important resource for ACEN-accredited programs is the ACEN Directors. Each Director has been in a leadership position in nursing education programs. An ACEN Director is assigned as a mentor to all programs that are seeking initial ACEN accreditation or going through the Follow-Up Reporting process if non-compliance is determined by the Board of Commissioners. The ACEN Directors are available to all currently accredited programs seeking continuing accreditation and welcome emails and calls to ensure accreditation questions are answered, challenges are addressed, and quality nursing education is achieved and maintained.

The ACEN also provides optional services that contribute to the quality of nursing education. For example, programs in Candidacy, or

those that are currently accredited, can observe the site visit of another program. The individual who wants to observe a site visit is required to complete the ACEN peer evaluator training. Training alone can be valuable to a faculty member or administrator wanting to better understand the ACEN Standards for quality nursing education, and the immersion experience of observing is even more impactful.

Another optional service offered by the ACEN is an Advisory Review. This review is an opportunity for a program to receive more extensive support and comprehensive feedback from an assigned ACEN Director. Ideally, the Advisory Review would take place 1–2 years before a scheduled site visit and may be conducted by video conference or in person. This service can help faculty to validate their understanding of how the quality Standards align with *their* program and/or identify areas where the program may be challenged to demonstrate compliance. These experiences support faculty to make necessary quality improvements before or between accreditation reviews.

Conclusion

Ultimately, nurse educators want to provide a quality nursing program and see their students be successful on the licensure examination as well as in their nursing careers. The ACEN Standards and accreditation process can assist programs in ensuring that the program maintains indicators of quality nursing education. If you have any questions related to the information provided, please do not hesitate to reach out to the ACEN either by email/phone or through our

general questions on the ACEN website. The ACEN Directors look forward to assisting you.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing personal relationships or financial interests that may have influenced the study reported in this paper.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Keri Nunn-Ellison: Conceptualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Melissa Tillson:** Writing – review & editing. **Suzette Farmer:** Writing – review & editing. **Nell Ard:** Visualization, Writing – review & editing. **Laura Polk:** Writing – review & editing.

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